

**High impact:** Mumbai's Shardul Thakur marked his presence with a 10-wicket haul against Assam.

EMMANUEL YOGINI

in trying to prioritise the Ranji Trophy. With the premier domestic tournament coinciding with the onset of winter in the northern part of the country, 24 out of the 44 matches that ended in a draw in the group stage were largely due to adverse weather. Additionally, 13 out of those 24 games lost at least an entire day's play. **Returning to the October-November window could be the way ahead, though the IPL auction, typically held in December, warrants the white-ball legs to be scheduled during that period.**

Also in focus was Ranji Trophy's Plate division, in which Hyderabad steamrolled its opponents, claiming six back-to-back innings-victories before beating Meghalaya by five wickets in the final.

Tanmay Agarwal's record fastest triple-hundred, off 147 balls, against Arunachal Pradesh, sparked a debate surrounding the First-Class status attributed to Plate games. Hyderabad smashed a whopping 529 runs in 48 overs on the opening day of that game.

While Hyderabad and Meghalaya will be promoted to the Elite division next season, Manipur (0 points) and Goa (4 points) are set to be demoted to Plate.

Though Delhi was staring down the barrel and looked set for relegation, with just one point after three games, it bounced back, amidst administrative issues and a mid-season captaincy switch, with three outright wins in its last four games to salvage some pride.

**As the curtains drew on the league stage, an era also ended with the likes of Manoj Tiwary, Saurabh Tiwary, Faiz Fazal, Dhawal Kulkarni and Varun Aaron walking into the sunset.** Though their influence on the international stage was limited, their dedication to the game serves as a fitting ode to contemporary domestic cricket — not always rewarding but a noble end in itself, nevertheless.



**THOUGH REITERATING THE IMPORTANCE OF PERFORMANCES ON THE DOMESTIC CIRCUIT IS A WELCOME MOVE, THE BCCI WILL ALSO HAVE TO DO ITS PART IN TRYING TO PRIORITISE THE RANJI TROPHY**